

GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT

Demo(n)Tapes

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Short summary of applied tools and link to project 1 video

Tools used:

Engine: Unity 6000.2.6f1

Language: C#

Programming environment: JetBrains Rider

Version Control: GitHub Desktop + Git

Graphics: Krita

Audio: FMOD Studio, Reason Studios Reason 13.x + Reaper, arsenal of VST plugins, basic band instruments, some other instruments

Design assistance: ChatGPT (OpenAI GPT-5)

Code/Documentation analysis: JetBrains AI Assistant (within Rider IDE)

Also add a link to the explanation video as instructed for Project 1 as a separate link:

<link to video here>

Game Design Document

- **Define your own game idea with minimum of 1-3 sentences per point.**
- **Consider the developed game from the viewpoint that you are actually making something which will be published at the end.**
- **Focus on the aspects 1-4, others you can define in more general terms since this is only the intro course into game development.**
- **The main aspects you are defining here are the following:**
 - **What would you like your game to look? Search or draw some concept art for your game, levels and characters.**
 - **What is the player doing in the game, what are the abilities of the characters?**
 - **What technological demands or requirements do you have? What technical aspects have to be solved for your idea to work?**
 - **What will your interface look like? What control scheme are you using and how does it work?**

Index

1. Executive Summary, Quick overview	5
2. Target Audience	6
3. Main Characters	7
4. Main Features	9
4.1 UI and UX	9
4.2 Core Gameplay Loop	11
4.3 Game Entity Characters, Operative agencies and character actions	13
4.4 Aspects, Ideas and Conveyance	17
4.5 Tags (Emotional / Ideological systems)	18
4.6 Tag-Pairs and genre specific systems	19
4.7. TRUE vs true, novelty, and gravity	20
4.8 Track Construction and Recording	22
4.9 Band and Collective Systems	24
4.10 Items and Item Mechanisms	25
4.11 Multiplayer Mode (The only game in town)	26
5. Genre, Setting, Concept Art book*	27
6. Enemies, NPCs, Other objects	28
7. Story board, script*	29
7.1 Story overview	29
7.2 Progression, World 1	29
7.9 Progression, World 2	29
8. Technical definitions, Tech guide*	30
8.1 Platforms, versions	30
8.2 Control Scheme	30
8.3 Limitations	30
9. Business definitions*	31
9.1 In-app purchases	31
9.2 DLC packs	31
10. Outsourced/Bought Assets	32
11. Technical Terms	33

1. Executive Summary, Quick overview

Demo(n)Tapes is a game inspired by the emerging 2nd wave black metal scene of the early nineties, set in a fictitious amalgam of all Nordic countries called Snordenmark (postal hyphen “SNO”), located in the middle of the Atlantic (roughly around where Iceland should be). It is also an art project that seeks to embrace both the DIY-spirit of the scene it simulates, and the anti-establishment attitude prevalent in it.

Each player controls a band leader visionary, who manages their own band amidst a larger clique of metal heads, surrounding a record shop (called The Hole) with rapidly changing management at the capital city of Snordenmark. The game is played in years and seasons or rounds and turns. The objective of the game is to nurture the sound of what is considered TRUE Black Metal, by participating in it through creation of demos, keeping those aspects that you have created and working against the parts that play tribute to other players efforts.

Actual success is measured against the dualism of elitism and poserdom. Elites represent street credibility and purity of intent, and posers represent cold hard cash. The player who is currently ahead is called the Keeper, and they are automatically put in charge of the record shop with all its services. When in charge of the record shop, the player cannot produce new material but must instead use their authority and other, subtler means to influence gameplay in their favour. A game of Demo(n)Tapes ends after a cataclysmic end-game event happens, towards which the game engine pushes the events in an organic fashion. The scene bubble might burst, ending the authenticity striving creation and replacing it with a formulaic and rigid type metal music emulating the last great bands. Or alternatively, such a drastic set of actions is taken in the name of authenticity, that the societal backlash simply wipes the scene away.

The project acts as a prototype for Scandinavian Extreme Metal Manager '91 (SEMM91), a future expansion (or the actual version 1.0), where the player manages their band in a *single player campaign*, with record labels, live gigs/tours, illegal notoriety operations and other such elements introduced. As it stands, Demo(n)Tapes is an online multiplayer game with limited features only.

2. Target Audience

Demo(n)Tapes seeks to capture the middle-aging casual gamers who recognize its underground aesthetic as its audience, the very people whom in general let out a muffled chuckle when they hear or see something darkly humorous or slightly off-kelter. This segment of society is not large by any means, but as stated in the executive summary, this is also an art project, so the creator will not live or die based on this project making it to the big leagues.

Obviously, if a gaming metalhead of any age sees a thumbnail that looks like a Darkthrone or Cannibal Corpse album cover, they are likely to click it to see what it is. They are not likely to face a price tag anytime soon, at least not under the Demo(n)Tapes monicker. If the demo becomes a thing, perhaps one day SEMM91 will become a reality.

A note on complexity: Demo(n)Tapes is designed with systemic simulations in mind, rather than as an easily approachable, content-driven management game. It seeks to purposefully consider and express topics such as ideological tension, scarcity and social power dynamics over optimization or linear progression. The many systems in place seek to establish a sense of instability instead of equilibrium.

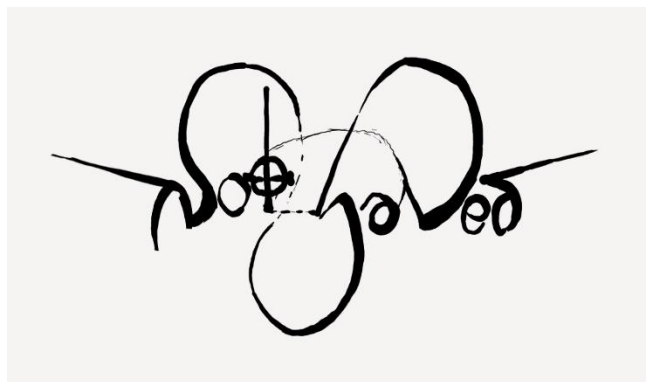
3. Main Characters

Nullsvorn from the band “**Not_Saved.SNO**” - the default player character.



The Player's alter-ego is a nameless and ambivalently gendered front-person of the snordanes black metal band “**Not_Saved.SNO**” by default. They can choose their stage name, which is by default “**Nullsvorn**”. The “. SNO” hyphen is determined from a drop-down menu, by the country of origin. Many or all these options might be locked down to their defaults, depending on where the project's development is currently at, and the same goes for the character's outlook, which would ideally be alterable. The band's logo is by default as depicted below.

Not_saved has been around for five or so years. A couple of fresh high school graduates formed it around '85. It used to do thrash metal covers but nowadays seeks to carve a path of their own into musical pathways seldom trodden.



The reversed cross in the logo is a nod to other bands and their aesthetics, but all the band members agree on one thing: *for metal to stand for something, one really must do an **inversion** of some sort*. Like go against established religion or state or something. Also, music should be True. Whatever that means. Who knows?

Nullsvorn as the band leader (a controller; see chapter 4) has their hands full with executive decisions such as how much of an effort the band in general puts to gestating (producing material; chapter 4), rehearsals or leisure time. Besides this, Nullsvorn is also the lyricist and the vocalist of the band, so they contribute the voice into the end goal of the band, which is always the next demo tape. There are three other **band members** (actors; chapter 4). One plays the bass, Sithrogürd, one plays the electric guitar, Keiser, and another does the drumming, Molotov. Sithrogürd has a brother, Oystein (an agent), who is hiding the police for trying to burn their ex's house, and the ex is also in play, dating Nullsvorn (a groupie).

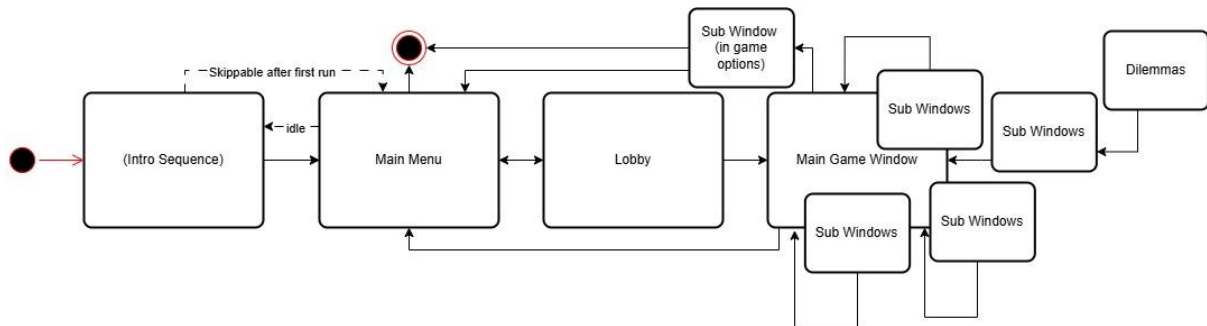
Each character who is directly participating in the demo recording process has **aspects** and **tags**. **Aspects** measure the way they participate – Nullsvorn's aspects are *fry-vocals* and *lyricism*. The band itself can also hold aspects: *corpse paint* and *true snordenmarkians*. Sithrogürd has *bass* and *arsonist*. Keiser has *guitar* aspect, and Molotov has both the *drummer* and *keyboard* aspects.

Nullsvorn holds the following tags at the beginning of the game: pagan, spiteful, infatuated (groupie). Most of the people Nullsvorn associates with are spiteful, negative people, so the “spiteful tag” is a **resonance tag** – one that sticks with the character and is tied to their overall circumstances in life. The spitefulness is a permutation of the malevolence tag. They are also feeling infatuated (a permutation of the vitality tag), which is a **mood tag** that can be resolved through simple actions. Mood changes faster than resonance. Finally, the Pagan tag (a permutation of the sacred tag) is a **conviction tag**. It means Nullsvorn leads a pagan lifestyle and can always opt to provide a pagan tag to any piece of music they are involved with. If Nullsvorn is somehow forced to commit actions that are against their conviction tag, their mood is likely to shift to a negative one.

If Nullsvorn spends an action gestating in the library, they can acquire a transient tag “violence”, because they spent a considerable effort studying the second world war. Nullsvorn can also go to a church and acquire “organized religion” as a transient tag, but it will disappear from their possession quickly, because it bothers them (due to the pagan tag).

4. Main Features

4.1 UI and UX



To play the game and navigate its contents, the player has access to different windows and interfaces. In quasi-chronological order:

1. Main Menu

- a. **Start Game** (The player enters a call-sign used to make a distinction from other players; the game checks if the call-sign is in use and asks for another if it is)
 - i. Start as host
 - ii. Join as client
- b. **Settings**
- c. **Exit**

2. Main game window

The basic window always features **a world map that gets updated after each turn**. The available interactions are highlighted as nodes on the map. Nodes are usually cities, and clicking on one opens a list of targets, which are more specific locations (a library, a police station, a church... etc). The immersion is backed with splashes that describe actions and their outcomes. The Main Game Window is always visible, but the action at hand can produce short time clutter over it. Keeper Window (a) or Player Window (b) is superimposed over the main window. Information window (c) is also available, regardless of player status (as keeper or regular).

Besides the world map, also a **thematic scene map** is present, depicting the composition of what is considered TRUE now, alongside with any formed subscenes and their TRUE compositions. Different audio representations of the sound of TRUE is accessible by fiddling with the thematic scene map, so hovering mouse over a certain TRUE TAG (see 4.5 and 4.6) causes a loop to be played.

a. Keeper window

- i. Keeper actions window** (Gate Keeping and management of the Hole). Keeper actions window accesses other player's band leaders as splashes and provides actions for and against them and their recordings. Keeper actions can also control all the promotion that takes place in The Hole, which is the most powerful place of promotion in the scene.

b. Regular player window

i. Gestation actions window

Gestation actions produce splashes that depict areas of interest where the player has chosen to send their actor. This could be a library, a mall, a police station, anything really. The operation is resolved on the splash window, after which the agent/actor has expended one action for the turn.

ii. Rehearsal actions window

Rehearsal actions window depicts the bands rehearsal space via a shaky camcorder, with each band member ready to interact with the task at hand via their chosen aspect (usually an instrument, see 4.2 and 4.3). The player gets to access each actor's available

tags and arrange them into tracks that first exist as ideas. In the rehearsal space, there is a 4-track recorder, which can be opened and used to create a record of the idea (process described at 4.7). There is also a shelf of VHS-cassettes, which serves as an access point to past arrangements. When a VHS tape is chosen during rehearsal actions, the UI tells if it's declared finished or not by showing a mess of hewed notes and beer bottles on a table vs. a clean table for a composed work.

iii. **Networking and promotional actions window**

Networking and Promotional actions allow characters to spread the word of their recordings in the game world via placing posters and sending tapes via mail. Promotional actions can also be used to vandalize or negate other bands promotional actions that have been taken on earlier turns. Sometimes the band might even do a gig.

- c. **Information Window** contains information of the overall game state and can be used to access each player's public game progress information, alongside the representation of players auditive work, if a tape is available. By default, the information window contains local players information. The other player's information is accessible only to the degree by which their sonic output has been made public either by personal promotional action or by having produced a tape that exists on the thematic scene map.

4.2 Core Gameplay Loop

A game of Demo(n)Tapes is played across a series of years (rounds), which are divided into four seasons (turns).

During each season, every collective (such as the player's band) chooses one collective action, and this action determines which character actions its members are allowed to perform. A band that is rehearsing can only perform rehearsal-related actions; a band that is gestating can only perform gestation-related actions, and so on.

During their character actions, controllers and actors generate ideas through their aspects, acquire transient tags from the world through interactions, and combine their existing tags into materials that can later be used in the recording process. Transient tags must be used quickly or they expire, and they are required for the creation of tag-pairs, which are necessary for producing tracks that are perceived as TRUE. Besides producing tracks, the band is expected to promote their art by playing shows at underground venues. Without visibility, they are at the mercy of the Keeper.

At the end of every season, the results of these actions update the band's creative progress, ideological profile, and influence over the scene. The culmination of their efforts materializes as demo tapes, which are shown as entities floating around a 3 dimensional ideological map, called The Scene Map. After every four seasons (one year), overall progress is evaluated, and the next year's Keeper is determined. The Keeper cannot produce new material but instead influences others from the position of authority, by allowing access to cheaper and specialised services. The Keeper's goal is to nurture their personal legacy by lifting bands that are following the Keeper's sound, instead of bands that are doing their own thing.

A band that gets on the wrong side of the Keeper must efficiently exist in the minds of the rest of the scene as the most radical and true cult example of it, up to a point in which the Keepers manoeuvring against them fails. This is accomplished by getting funded by sheer success and siphoning street credibility from the elites.

The loop repeats indefinitely, until an end-game event terminates the scene. An end-game action can be an outside force halting the scene's free action (because of too

much notoriety), or the concept of true getting somehow lost in the process. The elites can also determine all the scene's actors as posers and declare the scene dead.

4.3 Game Entity Characters, Operative agencies and character actions

Two broader types of operative agencies exist in the game. **Collectives** are usually bands (such as Not_saved), but any game entity that operates via agents could be depicted as a collective if such a scale is necessary. **Game Entities (often referred to as characters)** are individual game entities that can form collectives and are also divided into subcategories such as **Actors** (collective members) and **Controllers** (collective leaders). Even tracks and buildings are game entities, or perhaps even "characters", and hence a recording is a collective, and a bus station has a "mood" or character resonance to be exploited by other characters.

Game Entity derived characters (not including the inanimate examples of the last paragraph), are in descending order of agency as follows: Controllers, Actors, Agents and Groupies.

- **Controllers** are independent and authoritative characters who usually have the other character types as underlings via collectives or personal attachments. Band leaders are a common controller type.
- **Actors** are semi-independent characters who act within the context that something else has placed them in, such as band members. Actors can contribute to actions on the same level as controllers, but they rarely initiate anything by themselves.
- **Agents** are goons who are good at one or two things and must always be pointed towards what to do within those one or two realms of experience.
- **Groupies** are characters that mostly exist as a stat boost or as an attachment to another trait, usually a tag, such as for example Nullsvorn's infatuated (groupie) tag. A groupie could assist or hinder in a single action that the "owner" character performs. This class of characters is a nod towards the idea of it not being a good idea to bring spouses to rehearsal spaces.

The distinction between collectives and game entities splits actions (see below) into collective and character actions. A character within a collective has a set of character actions determined by which collective action their collective has taken (determined by the controller of that collective). A band that is rehearsing, has band members that can only do rehearsing actions.

A character can do several actions in one season as determined by the following design choice: **2 for free, third at cost (the 2:3 rule)**. The third action causes the character the “tired” status, which can be rested away with one skip character action per character. A character who is considered “tired”, cannot take a third action. Each type of action has its own special cost for the tiredness status, called strain penalty, which is active in play alongside the tired status. When the tired status is cured, so is the penalty. The strain penalty can only influence game play once per season. When the strain penalty is about to influence play, the character can opt out by taking a rest action. Keepers handle their Keeper strain penalty automatically, but their actions can keep them in the tired state indefinitely.

All character actions are declared asynchronously without players knowing about each other’s actions. The actions are resolved at the end of the turn, and in cases of shared targets between players, these actions are considered taken together. The current Keeper will interact with some character actions at the end of each turn, siding with them or against them.

As a point of clarification: If a character makes three actions in a season, regardless of their outcome, they will begin their next season tired. This tiredness then sets them up for a strain penalty in whatever collective action they have chosen. The only exception to this rule is if they get to be the next Keeper. Keeper doesn’t inherit tiredness from non-keeper actions. Likewise, the player who overplayed as keeper and then lost the position, won’t start their next season as a regular player tired.

4.3.1 Gestation Actions

Gestation actions create ideas, which are aspects that carry tags. Gestation actions also involve tape-trade and exchange of ideas in general between players. List of gestation actions:

- extract a resonance tag from another game entity into a character's transient tag slot
- impregnate an aspect with a tag from any own tag slot

Strain penalty: All over the place. The character must either play their transient tag into an idea or abandon it for another one available (within reach). At the end of the action, their transient tag must have changed, unless they rest instead.

4.3.2 Rehearsal Actions

Rehearsal actions are for sharpening the gestated ideas into perfection and recording them down unto a demo tape. When the band has chosen the collective rehearsal action, they are portrayed in their rehearsal space, where the player decides which track they are working on. When first entering rehearsal space, only "compose action" is available.

- Compose action either starts an empty track, to be named by the player as the first idea is placed on it or contributes to the track currently being worked on. The first idea is called "the root", and it can be any idea held by any band member. When at least one idea (a tag permutation + aspect) has been provided, the track can be declared composed, or left open for further compose actions.
- Rehearse action is used for improving the conveyance trait of the selected band member on the given track. A track that has not been rehearsed, or that has only been rehearsed max twice on, is considered "raw". The conveyance trait starts from around 0.5, depending on factors described later in this manuscript. Each rehearse action improves the conveyance trait towards the cap that is set up by the contributing band members aspect skill level.
- The conveyance score of a track consists of each individual tags conveyance median score.
- A track that has not been recorded yet exists as an open game object (a VHS tape with its name) that is interacted with via rehearse actions. If a C-cassette

is available, the band leader may choose the **Record Demo** option for the currently selected VHS tape, along with committing other selected tracks (VHS-tapes) into a demo tape release (see 4.7).

Strain penalty: Burnout. The character cannot access their mood tag slot, and lose momentarily the access to anything attached to it.

4.3.3 Promotional Actions

Promotional actions are for getting others acquainted with your materials beyond the Keeper's supervision.

Strain penalty: Too on the nose. The character must interact negatively with any instance of their convictional anti-tag at the next convenient moment, unless they take a rest instead.

4.3.4 Keeper Actions

Design intent: Keeper mechanics model informal gatekeeping common to small subcultures, where authority is influential but neither fully centralized nor fully transparent.

The Keeper has powerful, genre-bending decisions at their disposal. For example, they can declare a demo as black metal even if it lacks the genre defining re-sacralising tag-pair (see 4.5). They can lose other people's demos and thus hinder their circulation in the scene. They can also take credit from other people's actions at slightest hints of involvement. They can declare a relatively weak aspect or tag as heretical to the sound, or conversely, bring an aspect or tag that seems on the periphery of True into the fold legitimately. The price for these actions is that the next Keeper in line has access to the same actions and might be able to retaliate.

Keepers have a trait called "Pull", that is derived from their influence at the start of their position as Keeper. It is an expendable resource, that gets somewhat replenished at the start of each new round (unless the Keeper changes). All Keeper actions cost Pull, and the bigger the actions, the bigger the cost. If a keeper goes past their max Pull with an action, they can no longer do Keeper actions and are considered tired and suffer the strain penalty.

Strain penalty: Overreach. When a Keeper over plays their hand, they do not receive any influence points during the turn that they start with the penalty, nor do they replenish any Pull. A Keeper cannot circumvent this effect with rest, but the Keeper's tiredness is negated when this penalty is applied once. A Keeper who starts with no Pull can do one Keeper action as a sort of Hail Mary action, but this effectively keeps them in the sidelines if they somehow keep their status as Keeper.

4.4 Aspects, Ideas and Conveyance

An aspect is any trait an entity possesses that can host a tag to form an idea. For example, a guitar riff is an idea of the guitar aspect that has a tag conveying the author's intent.

An aspect does not do much by itself, but it can be instantiated into an idea, and an idea can (and must) host a tag (see below). Each character has a capacity to indefinitely hold a set number of ideas, but the idea must be built again once expended. A collective can also keep some ideas, and the association with those ideas is permanent and always accessible to the members of the collective.

Besides being the natural path for tags to come to play, aspects carry different kinds of modifiers, depending on how the scene prefers things to be handled. If corpse paint is something desirable in what is considered TRUE, then it yields a bonus for the band utilizing it. If the bagpipe aspect is considered something unheard of in the scene, it might carry a penalty, unless it manages to do the exact opposite and the novelty itself gives it a bonus instead.

Finally, on aspect relate note, there is a trait called **conveyance** attached to the idea, which stands for the level of clarity at which the idea can be presented. This is as close as we get to "musicianship" or "technical skill value" in this game. It's a normalized floating-point number that quite simply tells us how well the idea comes through to the audience.

When a demo tape is replicated, the conveyance score of the copy take a hit based on its **generation**, so its impact diminishes the wider the circulation it gets.

When an aspect gets to be played for the first time, it gets the **novelty factor** modifier for calculating influence.

4.5 Tags (Emotional / Ideological systems)

Tags are the single most important thing in the whole game because tracks are arrangements of tags served via aspects. Tags stand in relation with other tags, so a single tag has a so-called anti-tag and a few tags that have associations with the tag. For example, death's anti-tag is life, and it has an association (or permutations) with stillness, silence and darkness tags. Life, in turn, has an association with energy, noise and light. Usually, only the tag and perhaps its anti-tag are in play, but in few instances a tag can be played as one of its permutations. A person cannot hold both a tag and its anti-tag at the beginning of the turn.

Besides the three types of tags characters can possess (resonance, mood, conviction), controllers and actors can also have a transient tag, which is basically a tag they have acquired from somewhere else and are carrying but don't subscribe to themselves. A transient tag trait carries the latest tag that was acquired, unless the tag conflicts with the character's other tags, in which case it must be played within one turn before it gets nullified.

Every game entity object carries a permutation of at least one tag (resonance tag) which means that every such object in the game can be interacted with to reach for that tag. Tags can be found from other sources, too, such as in-season tags that are naturally provided by the current turn (autumn tags are morbid, winter tags are cold, for example). Some game events can spawn special tags, which tend to be the more valuable, the more rare or risky their acquirement is.

Resonance tags in a character's control can be used limitlessly without exhausting them. **Mood tags** can only be used twice per turn. If tried to access more, the third mood tag has a chance of being labelled "**simulacra**" which means it doesn't carry the actual emotional energy but goes through the motions only. As an idea, it has a diminished value. **A conviction tag** can be accessed any number of times per turn, but a third time it is used in the same record counts as **proselytizing**, which has a risk of behaving like a simulacra or cause scene splintering.

The exact lists of tags follow another design principle, **the rule of seven**. There are seven tag – anti-tag pairs (See chapter 11).

Tag permutations are the actual, concrete form in which the tag manifests in the game. Permutations themselves have further determination principles. For example, the tag Sacred, must manifest in a permutation such as “polytheist Nordic paganism”. Polytheism is the actual permutation, and the “Nordic paganism” part is a specific type of polytheism. Some permutations can be shared with different tags, so they can be played as any of these tags when they come to play – for example the permutation “energetic” is shared by the tags “Vital”, “Warm” and “Fast”. It is the permutation that is in play that is owned by the player who originally made it, but only in the context of the tag it manifests: If Player 1 introduced Energetic as a permutation of Fast, but Player 2 brought Energetic as a permutation of Vital, they are a different instance of Energetic. Player 3 must bring in Energetic as Warmth, or their progress is shared with player 1 or 2 (who played Energetic earlier and are likely already ahead).

4.6 Tag-Pairs and genre specific systems

Transient tags are used to create tag-pairs, which are special combinations of tags required to meet certain criteria in the creation of a record. To make a record that feels genuinely “blackened” (or TRUE), there must be a so-called **re-sacralising tag-pair** present in the record. Tag must be paired with its anti-tag.

So, to sum the process of building a re-sacralising tag-pair: Nullsvorn has the aspect lyricist, which allows them to create an idea that hosts a tag or a tag-pair. They can acquire the organized religion tag as a transient, and immediately (within a turn) place it inside a lyrical idea (so they do not have to carry it around as a transient). They attach the pagan tag into the same idea, so the pagan-organized religion tag pair is hosted safely inside the idea.

Nullsvorn can write lyrics about paganism all day long, but they must actively mock organized religion by building a pagan – organized religion tag-pair to their lyrics. The act of engaging with the subject matter is disturbing and builds into a visceral reaction on the record, which the listener can hear. The outcome is “serious”, not just a surface

act. So, a re-sacralising tag-pair is made of tag and its anti-tag, the latter which evaporates quickly unless it is pinned down somehow.

4.7. TRUE vs true, novelty, and gravity

Design intent: TRUE/true mechanics model authenticity as a contested, dynamic property that shifts through repetition, institutional influence, and social reaction.

The tag-pair concept is a deeper game mechanic than what is superficially considered “true” in the game. The surface level true is just the prevalent tags already present in the game as influential demo tapes. This simplistic level of true is the primary way in which the players accumulate resources. They make “true sounding” music for the scene by matching the correct tags and aspects to what is expected of them. “Screaming about the devil alongside basic band instruments played in a certain fashion” passes for true to most listeners. Each tag they manage to put to play, gives them a score yield (along with the person who originally put the tag in play).

However, if a release doesn’t contain a single instance of the blackened tag-pair, it is disqualified unless the Keeper declares the record as true black metal. Besides that, any aspect that carries a blackened tag pair can be played, even if the aspect itself is unconventional, and it automatically gains the novelty factor as an advantage. The only way to get a true black metal record ignored is if it isn’t promoted at all while the conveyance score of the demos in circulation erodes to such a low point that the intent doesn’t transmit to the listener at all, the master is destroyed, and the Keeper loses their copy “by mistake”.

A distinction between what is true on superficial level and what is true because of the tag-pair must be made. Hence, lowercase true means things that are accepted into the scene for the time being, and uppercase TRUE means the things that are undeniably legitimate no matter the perspective. A re-sacralising tag-pair is always TRUE. If something is considered True, it has a trait called **gravity**.

When a tag or tag-pair gets played as TRUE, it pulls all the other tags it accompanies on the recording with it further into the centre of the scene's thematics by the factor of its gravity. It also pushes against the anti-tag component with the same factor, if viable (the anti-tag is not likely in play as an individual entity). Gravity is also the value the Keeper must work against if they want to remove it from the table. The Gravity effect of a TRUE tag that carries three repetitions of a conviction permutation is proselytizing and can cause scene splintering.

4.8 Track Construction and Recording

Design intent: Production separates symbolic alignment from labour investment, allowing surface-level success without deep engagement, or deep engagement without immediate legitimacy.

Track construction and recording proceeds in three distinct phases: Gestation (idea and tag acquisition), Rehearsal (iterative development and refinement), and Recording (committing selected material to a demo tape).

The goal of the game is to create demo tapes, which are made of tracks, which are made of ideas, which are made of aspects and tag permutations. The aspects are held by actor and controller class game entities and tags are owned by all game entities, such as buildings and environments, not just people.

When a band leader chooses their band collective to go do gestate actions for the turn, the whole collective is locked into gestating actions (for descriptions of specific actions see 4.3). These actions have to do with extracting tags from game entities. It is easier to interact in this manner with things you “own” such as characters of your band, than with objects that stand outside of your immediate perimeter of control. For example, transient tags can be cloned between band members freely within one turn, and any band member’s tag can be accessed by any other band member’s gestation action. More on gestation in Band and Collective Systems (4.8.).

A demo recording of any length is created after a band collective is chosen to exist in rehearsal state and uses the demo recording action. The rehearsal state does not necessitate a product of a demo tape, instead, rehearsal by necessity produces or improves rehearsal tapes, which are depicted as VHS-recordings of the rehearsals in the game, stored in the band rehearsal space shelf. Each of these videos exist in an open state, whereby revisiting them and using rehearsal actions on them improves them (with the logic of diminished returns, of course). It’s only when the band leader chooses the record demo action for the current VHS tape that the audio recording is created. The player can then choose other tracks for the recording from the shelf as well, up to the maximum running time of the C-Cassette (46, 60 or 90 minutes). The

entire recording process takes one action per collaborator, regardless of the length of the tape. It is possible to record ones own material over another bands demo, and even copy a third party's effort over another, should a copy ever reach ones hands. A track that ends up on a demo tape while considered not fully composed receives "sketchy" trait. A sketchy track cannot have a conveyance score above 80%. It is also considered "raw" for as long as the condition persists.

Once recorded, a demo tape usually enters circulation and becomes eligible for promotion, degradation through copying, Keeper intervention, and representation on the thematic scene map.

4.9 Band and Collective Systems

- The tape exchange and cultural dynamics are going to be explained here

4.10 Items and Item Mechanisms

- I will be explaining tape and cassette mechanisms here, along with the soft economy of the game

4.11 Multiplayer Mode (The only game in town)

- A short description of how a game session of Demo(N)Tapes works at a networking level

5. Genre, Setting, Concept Art book*

- Keep this short

6. Enemies, NPCs, Other objects

I can describe classes here in technical detail if I want to

7. Story board, script*

7.1 Story overview

7.2 Progression, World 1

7.9 Progression, World 2 ...

Here I will describe the 2 or three ways the game can run in the largest scope with the endings.

8. Technical definitions, Tech guide*

8.1 Platforms, versions

8.2 Control Scheme

8.3 Limitations

9. Business definitions*

9.1 In-app purchases

9.2 DLC packs

10. Outsourced/Bought Assets

Topics with () usually extended to separate detailed documents, in this project can be simply summarized*

11. Technical Terms

Term	Definition
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Actor	Semi-autonomous character acting within a collective (e.g., band members).
Snordenmark (SNO)	Fictional Nordic amalgam nation and primary setting.
Keeper	Player currently leading; runs the record shop and wields powerful scene-shaping actions.
Elites	Hardcore listeners forming the credibility core of the scene. Elites are hypersensitive to authenticity and react very badly to things such as simulacra.
Posers	Mainstream audience reflecting commercial appeal.
Scene	The Snordenmark black metal subculture and its fluctuating thematic centre.
SEMM91	Scandinavian Extreme Metal Manager '91; planned expanded single-player version.
Year (Round)	Full cycle of four seasons.
Season (Turn)	One playable time segment within a year.
End-game Event	Cataclysmic event that collapses the scene and ends the game.
Game Entity	Any object that can hold tags (characters, buildings, environments, tracks).
Collective	A group of game entities acting together (e.g., a band, a recording).
Controller	High-agency character; defines collective actions (e.g., band leaders).
Agent	Low-autonomy helper character specializing in 1–2 tasks.
Groupie	Attachment/stat-boost character linked to another character or tag.
Track	A single recorded piece composed of ideas.
Demo Tape	A collection of tracks; main goal of the game loop.
Transient Tag Slot	Storage slot for a temporary, uncommitted tag.
Collective Action	A unified action chosen for an entire collective (e.g., rehearse, gestate).
Character Action	An individual's action within the constraints of the collective action.
Gestation Actions	Actions for extracting tags, creating ideas, and exchanging concepts.

Term Definition

Rehearsal Actions	Actions improving conveyance and developing tracks inside the rehearsal space.
Promotional Actions	Actions that spread material beyond Keeper control.
Keeper Actions	High-impact actions used to shape the scene's expectations or sabotage others.
Compose Action	Begins or extends a track by placing ideas; defines the root of the track.
Rehearse Action	Improves a character's conveyance rating on a track.
Rest Action	Skips activity to remove Tired status and avoid strain penalties.
Aspect	A trait capable of hosting tags (e.g., guitar, corpse paint, lyricism).
Idea	An instantiated aspect carrying one or more tags.
Root (Idea)	The first idea placed on a track; defines its initial structure.
Conveyance	Normalized float describing how clearly an idea is delivered (0.0–1.0).
Novelty Factor	Influence bonus applied the first time an aspect is used in the scene.
Tag	Core emotional/ideological semantic marker.
Anti-Tag	The opposing tag in a tag-pair.
Associated Tag	Tags thematically linked to the base tag.
Resonance Tag	Long-term identity tag; unlimited use.
Mood Tag	Short-term emotional tag; limited uses per turn.
Conviction Tag	Deep belief tag: multiple uses possible but repeated use becomes proselytizing.
Transient Tag	Temporary tag acquired from interactions; must be used or it fades.
In-Season Tag	Tags naturally available during specific seasons (e.g., morbid in autumn).
Special Tag	Rare or risky tag obtained from specific events.
Tag-Pair	Combination of a tag and its anti-tag or special structured combination.
Re-sacralising Tag-Pair	Core TRUE-defining black metal tag-pair (tag + anti-tag).
De-sacralising Tag-Pair	Tag + NULL tag pair (death metal logic; future scope).
Sacralising Tag-Pair	Double-tag pair (doom metal logic; future scope).
Simulacra	An emulated version of a mood tag when used beyond its limit, or without the required mood available in the first place. For Posers.
TRUE (uppercase)	Content mechanically legitimized by re-sacralising tag-pair.
true (lowercase)	Scene-conforming surface-level aesthetic or trend.

Term Definition

Gravity	Pull exerted by TRUE tags; shapes the scene's thematic centre.
Gravity Factor	Amount of thematic pull exerted by a TRUE tag or pair.
Tired Status	Condition acquired from taking a third character action in a season.
Strain Penalty	Negative effect specific to each action type upon overexertion.
All Over the Place	Gestation strain penalty; forces transient tag resolution or replacement.
Burnout	Rehearsal strain penalty: character loses access to mood tag for the turn.
Too on the Nose	Promotional strain penalty; forces negative interaction with convictional anti-tag.
Overreach	Keeper strain penalty: blocks influence gain and Pull replenishment.
Influence	Abstract measure of standing within the scene.
Influence Points	Quantified influence accumulated per actions/tags/tracks.
Pull	Expendable Keeper resource used to pay for Keeper actions.
Generation (of Copy)	The duplication depth of a tape; each generation reduces conveyance.
the 2:3 rule	An entity can make two actions and one extra at a cost.
the rule of 7	The number 7 serves as a standard for sets, or as a cap of sets. For example, there are 7 tag – anti-tag pairs, and a band (in this game) can have 7 members at most.
scene splintering	A scene can form within a scene, based on a proselytizing TRUE tag pair.
VHS tapes	Represent the bands current handling of a given track, built over time in the rehearsal space. During live shows, bands perform their tracks at the level of the VHS tape, not the demo tape release. VHS tapes erode slowly while they sit on the shelf, representing the band losing touch with their old material.
C-cassettes	These tapes have varying runtimes, and they can be over written.

Tag – Anti-tag pairs

Tag	Anti-Tag	Axis
Profane	Sacred	Transgression vs Sanctification
Cold	Warm	Emotional Distance vs Immediacy
Raw	Honed	Expression vs Refinement
Fast	Slow	Urgency vs Deliberation

Malevolent	Benevolent	Hostility vs Altruism
Morbid	Vital	Death Fixation vs Life Force
Void	Meaning	Nihilism vs Purpose